

automatically boots from the hard disk). After a jab at the *Enter* key, the screen went blank.

Not for long. Just a split second later, a screen with the message "Windows Is Loading Files" along with a progress bar appeared. It then completed a graphical boot screen and displayed four balls converging into a Windows flag and a lot of HDR effects. The screen was set at the full 1024x768 pixels resolution, with 32-bit colour. Too little, too late: we already have this animated graphical boot capability in RHGB, which was demonstrated by Fedora 10.

The installer took almost a minute to start, which is way too long for our liking. Anyway, once it was up, a screen came up asking for language and locale selection. We selected English (India) as our language, and let the other settings be. Then we hit *OK*. A second screen came up, with a big 'Install Now' button amongst other things. We hit that as well. The set-up program thus got initiated, taking another minute to load. What's with Windows and speed?

The first screen showed us a licence agreement. You know what Microsoft EULAs are! Anyway, without accepting it, we could not try it out, so we accepted it with a heavy heart. The next screen threw up a surprise: it was meant to ask us whether to upgrade or perform a new installation. Typical of Microsoft confusion-creating terminology, the new installation option is called 'Custom'. But accompanying it was a common Microsoft Bug—the upgrade option was enabled, and below it was clearly stated, "The Upgrade option is enabled only when you are installing Windows from within an Operating System that can be upgraded to Windows 7".

We hit the *Custom* button. A partition selection screen showed up, where we selected Disk 1 Partition 0 (which means the first partition of the second disk, which GRUB guys will know :-)). It was unformatted (as we had prepared it). We hit *Next*, and whoa, installation had started before we knew it. Installation took a long time, and at the end of it, the thing rebooted the PC

into Windows 7. The first run wizard then asked for a user name, a password, and most annoyingly, a password hint. Now Microsoft is just slashing open a security hole by enforcing that feature. It put the PC through its paces, ran some hardware detection, asked what type of network we were in, and finally took us to the desktop.

Over the entire procedure, the set-up program had installed the Windows Boot Manager onto the first partition superblock and written a new MBR chainloading the first partition, thus effectively destroying GRUB. Windows XP was detected, but no sign of Fedora 10 remained. The entire procedure took 16 minutes plus user interaction time. Way too slow. On the upside, the Windows set-up looks very sleek and superbly streamlined, and it was a pleasure to actually install Windows, save the nasty Fedora busting surprise at the end (but it wasn't supposed to work anyway).

Mandriva was a whole new story. We put the DVD in, and the first thing we knew was that a cool blue 'fishy' menu with some menu items for installing, rescuing, checking our hardware and booting from the first hard disk, had come up. We would have preferred a "Press any key..." prompt to save the overhead of starting the CD boot manager, however. We just hit *Enter*, and after a text-mode phase the GUI installer started up.

The Mandy installer doesn't look anywhere near as sleek as Windows 7's, and at first glance has twice as many steps compared to Windows' set-up. The installer is arranged rather like Windows XP's, with a list of steps stacked in a sidebar at the left of the screen, and wizard dialogs exactly like the WINNT32.EXE installer, only a lot prettier. The first screen is for selecting the system locale, of course. No English (India) here, so we had to settle for English (British). We accepted the licence agreement (which informed us that there was no warranty) and then moved on to partitioning. Partitioning manually was a confusing affair for a new user, compared to Windows 7. Then on, it was smooth sailing.

After selecting the root partition, we were asked if we

